

Speak, talk, say, and tell

Teaching guide

Choose a verb that fits the message and listener.

Understand the distinction

Say focuses on the words or message: She said hello; she said that she was busy. Tell commonly names the listener directly: She told me that she was busy. Use say something to someone, not say someone something.

Speak and talk often overlap for conversation. Speak is common with languages: speak Arabic. Talk about introduces a topic. Learn common exceptions as phrases: tell a story, tell the truth, speak to someone, talk to or with someone.

Compare the patterns

MESSAGE

She said the meeting was canceled.

The focus is the message.

LISTENER

She told me the meeting was canceled.

Me identifies the listener.

TOPIC

We talked about the schedule.

About introduces the topic.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: She said me the answer.

- A. She said me to the answer.
- B. She told to me the answer.
- C. She told me the answer.

2. Complete: Do you ___ Korean?

- A. speak
- B. say
- C. tell

3. Does tell always need a listener?

- A. No. Tell can never name a listener.
- B. Yes. Every use must name a listener.
- C. No. Common phrases include tell a story and tell the truth.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Your colleague gave you a message about a new room. Which report is grammatical and names the recipient?

- A. My colleague said me that the room had changed.
- B. My colleague told to me that the room had changed.
- C. My colleague told me that the room had changed.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. She told me the answer.

Alternatively: She said the answer to me.

A: Say does not take a person directly in this pattern. Use She told me the answer.

B: Tell takes the recipient directly here: told me the answer.

2. A. speak

Speak is the usual verb for language ability.

B: Speak is used for knowing or using a language.

C: Tell normally communicates a message; speak Korean names a language ability.

3. C. No. Common phrases include tell a story and tell the truth.

Learn the whole phrase with its meaning.

A: Tell me and tell the team are normal patterns.

B: Expressions such as tell the truth do not need an explicit listener.

4. C. My colleague told me that the room had changed.

Told me names the recipient and introduces the reported message.

A: Say does not take me directly in this pattern; use told me or said to me.

B: Tell takes the recipient directly here: told me.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-36.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Your colleague gave you a message about a new room. Which report is grammatical and names the recipient?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.